

DOWNTOWN

Sunday
March 8, 2026

THE HINDU

TAMBARAM

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T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

On March 2, bhoomi pooja was conducted for the work aimed at elevating Alandur pedestrian pathway to a two and three-wheeler-cum-pedestrian subway. MLA T. M. Anbarasan laid the foundation stone.

This has been a long-standing plea of motorists. They had made this plea known to the State Highways Department as this infrastructural upgrade would prevent them from going the extra mile to take a U-turn.

At present, motorists from St. Thomas Mount Railway Station Road and Subway Lane Road have to navigate GST Road and take a U-turn along



▼ The subway and (right) the U-turn at St Thomas Mount. PHOTOS: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Work on Alandur pedestrian pathway begins

St. Thomas Garrison Church.

A. Rajesh, a motorist, said, “The traffic flow along the sub-

way is never-ending as motorists come from Guindy, Alandur and descend from

Ekkattuthangal and Vadapalani. The lane is also wide.”

Motorists from Railway Sta-

tion Road and the Subway Lane Road must drive carefully to reach along the medians as there are no speed breakers, says V. Rama Rao, director, Traffic and Transportation Forum.

The other option is to drive left and approach the medians along St. Thomas Mount post office, where traffic slows due to U-turn signals. The other option is to stop at the signal on the left, then take the U-turn.

If the underpass is made a vehicular subway, it will reduce the time to reach the lane towards Kathipara Grade Separator against the present U-turn, alleviate risk and save fuel.

The project is expected to be completed in six months at a cost of ₹8.13 crores.



No leg space, inside and outside

Visitors to the Pallavaram Sub-Registrar Office flag lack of space, absence of basic amenities and a narrow road right outside with a built-in congestion problem

T. ARVIND

Visitors have raised concerns over severe space constraints and lack of basic amenities at the Pallavaram Sub-Registrar Office located in New Colony, Chromepet. The cramped premises not only delay registration procedures but also lead to crowds spilling onto the street, aggravating traffic congestion along the already narrow road.

Inadequate infrastructure

According to activist Rajendran, the Sub-Registrar Office on Second Main Road in New Colony is among the top revenue-generating registration zones in Tamil Nadu. Despite operating for more than two decades, the office continues to function from a small rented building with inadequate infrastructure.

“Authorities have been saying for years that the office will be shift-

ed to a larger premises, but there has been no progress in this direction so far,” he said.

Seniors affected

Social activist V. Santhanam pointed out that elderly visitors are particularly affected by the lack of basic facilities. “Senior citizens who come for document registrations often have to wait for long hours. There is not even a toilet facility available for them,” he said.

Inside the office, there are barely a dozen chairs for visitors. Most people are forced to stand near the counters while waiting for their turn.

A staff member at a nearby advocate’s office said visitors frequently request access to their restroom facilities in emergencies. “We feel bad turning them away, but the shop owner does not allow outsiders to use the restroom,” she said.

Santhanam added that couples who arrive for marriage registra-



▼ Visitors crowd Pallavaram Sub-Registrar Office and vehicles parked along the narrow Second Main Road near the Pallavaram Sub-Registrar Office in Chromepet. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND

tion are often seen waiting outside in the sun, dressed in traditional attire and wearing garlands, as there is no waiting space inside the office.

Token system

Officials said around 100 tokens are issued daily for registrations, with

the number exceeding 150 on Fridays and other auspicious days.

“However, not even 20 people can comfortably stay inside the office at a time,” Rajendran said, adding that the record room storing important documents is located in a dilapidated portion of the building, raising concerns about the sa-

fety of records.

When contacted, Sub-Registrar Ezhilarasan said the process of identifying a new building for the office was “under way”.

A narrow road

Apart from the cramped office, activists said traffic congestion outside the premises has become a major concern.

The road where the office is located is close to wedding halls, hospitals, medical colleges, schools and hotels, leading to heavy vehicular movement. Though the road was originally about 30 feet wide, activists say it has effectively narrowed by nearly half due to foot-path construction and haphazard parking on both sides.

Arguments between residents and visitors over vehicle parking are common. “One house owner even sold his property and moved away because of the constant chaos,” Rajendran said.

New complex proposed

Pallavaram MLA E. Karunanidhi said he had raised the issue multiple times in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly.

He said an alternative site near the Taluk Office in Zamin Pallavaram has been identified for constructing a new building that will house both the District Registrar’s Office and the Pallavaram Sub-Registrar Office.

“An estimate of over ₹4 crore for the project was forwarded to the Registration Department in December 2025 for approval. We have also requested the Tambaram Corporation Commissioner to provide the required no-objection certificate and council resolution,” he said, adding that the approvals are expected soon.

Interim facilities

Santhanam said that until the new building is constructed, temporary measures such as providing restrooms and additional seating for visitors should be arranged at the existing office.

Residents oppose **sewage treatment** plant near lake

A protest meeting held on March 1 to save Madambakkam lake had residents participating in it in good numbers

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

On March 1, close to 200 residents of Madambakkam attended a protest meeting to Save Madambakkam Lake. They urged the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to drop the plan to establish a Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) in the vicinity of Madambakkam Lake.

Brigadier (retired) Mohan Thomas, a social activist, who took part in the meeting, says, "The STP should be commissioned far away from the crowded localities and not near the Madambakkam lake. A waterbody must receive fresh rainwater and not treated water."

Residents are dependent on groundwater replenished by the



Residents at the meeting to save the lake. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

lake. "The lake will become a septic tank, and the groundwater will be ruined," he said.

Apart from the impact the plant will have on the groundwater, there is also a threat to Indian Air Force aviators due to bird issues, said Mohan Thomas.

Residents also fear stench from

sewage overflow and impact during monsoon. "The proposed site is approximately one kilometre from the edge of the runway and directly in the aircraft's flight path," he said. Sewage will flow into the STP via the network, known as the influent. These influents, when treated in the plant, will produce

the sludge. The treated water is proposed to be channelised into the lake. "Water treated by a secondary stage treatment process is not fit for channelisation into a static waterbody. If this happens, the lake will be deprived of oxygen and, in a short period of time, will become poisonous," say residents.

'30,000 people live around the proposed site'

Near Shridhi Sai Nagar, Madambakkam, Tambaram City Municipal Corporation plans to install a sewage treatment plant (STP).

The proposal was halted more than a decade ago, but it has now been reinitiated.

The Shridhi Sai Nagar is a densely populated residential area, and the proposed STP would pose the risk of pollution and lead to health risks to residents, especially children and senior citizens.

I strongly urge the authorities concerned in the civic body to reconsider this plan and explore alternative locations that are far from residential areas. There are more than 30,000 residents in and around the proposed site.

Beena Anil is a resident of Shridhi Sai Nagar

A dedicated group for **women** on Radial Road

The Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations (FORRRRA) celebrated its first Women's Day on March 1 called 'Radial Women Rising', bringing together women from gated communities along the arterial Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam 200 Feet Radial Road.

The celebration witnessed the participation of more than 150 women, with over 60 enthusiastically taking part in various cultural and interactive programmes. The event featured programmes such as a Pattimandram, dance and singing and the inspiring 'Bold You' walk, which encouraged women to express confidence and solidarity,

said a release.

The initiative also led to the formation of a dedicated WhatsApp group to help women on Radial Road stay connected beyond the event. "A new WhatsApp group was formed for all of us. This group has become a space for us to stay connected, share ideas, support one another and exchange opportunities. This way we have kept the conversation going beyond Women's Day celebrations and we will ensure this network grows stronger every day," said B. Vijayalakshmi, founder-president of the Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations, in a press release.



Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road. PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK

Danger lurks not just on the bends

Metal barricade medians have been grouted into the bends along the section of Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road that traces the Kelambakkam backwaters; a couple of wider straights also need this protective measure

PRINCE FREDERICK

Parade before your mind's eye roads that seem to have been "carefully crafted" for head-on collisions? That might sound morbid, but on certain roads, at least certain sections of them, that thought cannot be avoided; motorists moving in opposite directions seem to be charging at each other.

In the heart of the city, moto-

rists might find that unsavoury thought sneaking in on them, while navigating certain sections of Kamarajar Salai (Beach Road hugging the Marina), particularly while Father Time has entered the liminal zone between late evening and early night. Anyone accustomed to taking the Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road would find themselves thinking along the same lines while navigating the section of the road

that traces the Kelambakkam backwaters and its adjacent patches.

This section of the link road is hugely narrow but that does not deter motorists from speeding. A majority of road users hitting the link road having no business to transact on this section of the road (exceptions include those in the fish-and-crab catching business, staff at the ICAR-CIBA Kovalam Experimental Station, and anglers and birders and other Nature enthusiasts without a clear-cut agenda). Adding to the risk, this section sports some bends. To alleviate the danger arising from the road's design, short medians of metal barricades have now been grouted into the road at these high-risk bends, making sure vehicular traffic moving in one direction does not spill over into the path of the other. This is just what the doctor ordered for preventing head-on collisions. But the traffic planners have failed to turn over the prescription sheet and read the additional instruction the doctor has scrawled on the other side. The helpfulness of having these grouted metal medians in the slightly wider straights as well to blunt the natural deadly edge this road possesses. Accidents are equally likely, if not more so, on the slightly wider straights, where motorists can let their guard down, unlike while they are on then bends.

This is the first sighting of the Demoiselle Crane anywhere in the Chennai Metropolitan Area. Naman Bora and Amogh Chatty found the vagrant bird feeding in the reeds at the salterns on February 28

A **'ballerina'** shows up at Nemmeli Salt Pans



A vagrant Demoiselle Crane at Nemmeli Salt Pans photographed by Naman Bora on March 1 and (below) by Amogh Chatty on February 28.

mented sighting of the bird in Chennai.

Gnanaskandan Kesavabharathi, a senior reviewer at eBird, confirms it and places this individual bird in its life stage based on its features: "It is a sub-adult bird considering the white near throat and forehead, short white ear tufts and the brownish orange iris versus a reddish iris in full adults."

That this bird is a lone vagrant and no "relative" was keeping lock-step with its peregrinations into uncharted territory was confirmed the following morning. Naman observes that on Sunday morning (March 1) he went with wildlife photographer Sudharshan Kuselan to the Nemmeli salt pans and the duo found the Demoiselle Crane around the same spot. Naman displayed greater tenacity, returning to the spot for another two days (March 2 and 3) and found the bird matching his tenacity. Naman observes that the bird was tenaciously clinging on to its feeding spot in the reeds, being found within 100 metres of the spot it was first seen at. "After roosting, it would return to this feeding spot," Naman adds.

Gnanaskandan notes two earlier records of Demoiselle Crane sighting for Tamil Nadu exist. Both have come from Vijaynarayanam Tank in Tirunelveli: two birds sighted in 2006, and one in 2007.

Weighing in on this sighting at Nemmeli, ornithologist V. Shantaram places it in perspective: "A majority of Demoiselle Crane sightings are from western India, specifically Gujarat and Rajasthan. At Khichan Village in Rajasthan, sighting a flock of 4,000-5,000 Demoiselle Cranes is not uncommon. Those are the places they normally visit, but they do move around. These birds are great wanderers. I mean they come from Central Asia and fly down to Gujarat and for them to come down south is not a big thing, but they do not have to unless there is a drought or there is some other reason for their movement. It could be one of those reasons, or just that some of the birds are more adventurous. There are a lot of possibilities; they probably come in here regularly in small numbers (during winter) and we have missed them out."

On the Demoiselle Crane's forays into the south, Shantaram points out there are "records near Bangalore and around Mysore; in Tirunelveli; and "in northern Karnataka, it seems to be fairly regular". On habitats the Demoiselle Crane is drawn to, Shantaram says: "They are found near waterbodies, but they feed in the fields where different kinds of crops are grown. They also feed in the open areas around tank shores that are drier."

PRINCE FREDERICK

Marie Antoinette's image has been shaped by words not her own, but consistently put in her mouth through the centuries. Two things she did not say continue to be misattributed to her. One, the suggestion that the poor French peasants could have cakes if they lacked bread. And the other, oddly, has to do with ornithology. She is believed to have given Demoiselle Crane its name impressed by its uber-feminine movements, largely dance-like. Anyone in India faintly familiar with French having taken it up to bump up the aggregate in their higher secondary board exams, as this writer did decades ago, would realise Demoiselle is from French and a variant of Mademoiselle, denoting a young lady. Back to Marie and her putative bird-christening abilities, this bird was given that name for its ultra-feminine demeanour but not by her. Here is why.

The infamous French queen was born in 1755, and an account of why the bird goes under the name Demoiselle Crane is found, with an illustration, in George Edwards's *A Natural History of Uncommon Birds*, its various volumes written between 1743 and 1751. Even if the account about the Demoiselle Crane spilt out of the quilt-pen in 1751, it is a good four years before Marie arrived. The book is in the



public domain, accessible at Biodiversity Heritage library (biodiversitylibrary.org).

The truth in fact runs deeper, the bird's name and its significance preceding the book.

Why harp on Marie Antoinette and the Demoiselle Crane now? Here is answering this question

nagging the reader. On the evening of February 28, 2026, two youngsters from Chennai were treated to a ballet performance by the "made-moiselle" at the Nemmeli salt pans. Naman Bora, a sophomore-student at VIT on Kelambakkam-Vandalur High Road and Amogh Chatty, a Class X student of PSSBB Millenni-

um at Semmancherry, both members of Madras Naturalists Society (MNS) sighted and photographed a lone vagrant Demoiselle Crane (*Grus virgo*) while it was feeding among the reeds and while it was in flight.

The record of the sighting is up on eBird; and it is the first docu-

Have you invited a **Madras Mali** to your garden?

They grow gardens in other people's backyards but the blooms extend into their living rooms. On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme designed by Chennai Resilience Centre



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Many had spent years as homemakers with little opportunity for paid work. Today, as part of the Madras Malis initiative, they travel across neighbourhoods helping households establish and maintain organic kitchen gardens.

The programme traces its roots to the Chennai Resilience Centre's Chennai Urban Farming Initiative, launched in 2021 to promote organic edible gardening in urban spaces. The idea was simple: encourage residents to grow food at home, both as a source of nutrition and as a way to create greener, climate-resilient neighbourhoods where plants help reduce urban heat. Workshops and training sessions were organised with residents, teachers and community groups across the city. But as participation grew, organisers began noticing a recurring challenge. While many residents were eager to start kitchen gardens, sustaining them required technical knowledge most did not possess.

"Residents often told us that even after attending workshops, maintaining a garden was still difficult," says Ayesha Ajmal, Junior Re-

search Associate and Communications Manager at the Chennai Resilience Centre, who coordinates Mali assignments, manages social media, and assists with training sessions. "There were challenges with pests, soil health and identifying the right inputs to use."

Organisers also recognised another gap. While gardeners were available in the city, most focused on routine tasks such as watering or pruning. Few had the expertise to maintain edible gardens using organic techniques or diagnose plant health problems.

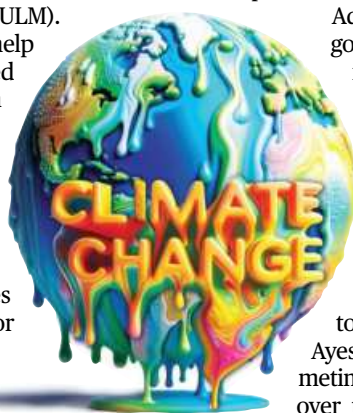
To address this, while also creating livelihood opportunities, the initiative began collaborating with the Tamil Nadu Urban Livelihoods Mission (TNULM). Women from self-help groups were invited to participate in specialised gardening training. This effort gradually evolved into the Madras Mali programme. Ayesha underlines that eligibility for participating in the training

programme is predicated on a woman's membership in a self-help group registered under TNULM.

Between 2022 and 2024, the initiative operated as a pilot under the Urban Thottam project, experimenting with training formats while connecting trained women with households seeking help. By 2025, the programme was formally structured and launched under the name Madras Mali, with a dedicated website, social media presence and a defined list of services. Since 2023, nearly 250 women have received training. The training is designed in stages. Participants begin with fundamentals – soil preparation, plant varieties and common pests.

Advanced sessions go deeper into pruning, identifying fungal infections and diagnosing nutrient deficiencies. "These sessions are usually conducted in modules lasting around two to three hours,"

Ayesha explains. "Sometimes they take place over two or three days



M. Krishnaveni (wearing a hat) from Chintadripet talks to a client about a plant; V. Prabha from R.A. Puram and B. Geetha from Taramani, also at work in their respective client's garden. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their confidence. B. Geetha from Taramani says the work has given her a sense of financial independence. "Earlier, I depended on my husband even for small things. If my children asked for a pencil or a book, I had to ask him for money. Now I can manage these small expenses myself." Appreciation from residents keeps her motivated too. "Residents sometimes send photos of the harvest. Seeing that makes me feel very satisfied." Others say the programme has expanded their world beyond their immediate neighbourhoods.

V. Prabha from R.A. Puram, who has been working as a Mali for three years, says the experience has made her more confident. "Earlier I hardly stepped outside my area. Now I know some bus routes and I can interact with more people." Gardening has also become a passion. "I keep encouraging people around me to grow more plants at home."

Their work has extended beyond private homes to schools and community institutions, including a Greater Chennai Corporation High School at Kamaraj Avenue in Adyar, the Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust in Teynampet, Little Flower Nursery and Primary School in Adambakkam and Government Higher Secondary School in Sholinganallur. Students are often involved in sowing and harvesting, turning gardens into learning spaces, with vegetables sometimes used in the institutions' kitchens. "Seeing them eat the greens they harvest for lunch feels more fulfilling than the money," says one of the Madras Malis, M. Krishnaveni from Chintadripet.

The challenges

Like many livelihood initiatives, the programme comes with challenges. Working through Chennai's summers can be gruelling, and the work occasionally involves physically demanding tasks such as carrying heavy pots. Managing client expectations has also required attention; organisers now address this by clearly explaining the scope of work to both parties before assignments begin.

Despite these challenges, the initiative continues to grow largely through word of mouth. Many clients who first hear about the service through friends or neighbours eventually become repeat users. Those interested in availing the Madras Mali service can contact the team via WhatsApp at 9176588007. More details are available at urbanthottam.com/madras-mali-veg-garden-kit/ and @urbanthottam on Instagram.



depending on the women's availability."

Beyond classroom sessions, participants are also exposed to organic farming at scale. In late 2023, a group attended a residential programme at a farm run by the Centre for Indian Knowledge Systems near Vedanthangal, where they explored traditional vegetable varieties, visited rice fields and participated in organic farming demonstrations.

The programme also emphasises entrepreneurial skills. Participants learn to prepare organic pesticides and plant growth promoters using locally available ingredients, which they can market to clients. They are also trained to set up composting systems and guide households in converting kitchen waste into compost. For the Malis, minimum payment is fixed at ₹850 for five hours; the Malis receive the payment directly from the clients and Chennai Resilience Centre does not receive a commission.

A confidence boost

For many participants, the most visible transformation has been in

Where does the sun shine the brightest?

In Tamil Nadu, Chennai secures the second slot in terms of adoption of solar energy through rooftop installations. Coimbatore tops the table. Chengalpattu is in the third position

LIFFY THOMAS

On February 23, 2026, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on X praised India's rooftop solar adoption that has powered 30 lakh households since the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana was launched two years ago. A remarkable milestone in India's clean energy transition. The question closer home would be: two years on, where does Tamil Nadu stand?

According to data shared by Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited, 55,328 households have installed rooftop photo voltaic solar power systems in Tamil Nadu until February 28, 2026.

Tamil Nadu is in the 11 position, with states such as Gujarat, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh ahead of it. For rankings, an official say, one should refer the number of installation on the PM Surya Ghar portal, which is total number of individual installation plus the number of installations done by flats (RWA).

In Tamil Nadu, Coimbatore leads among the districts for completing the maximum number of installations, followed by Chennai (see box).

Those working in the industry say the State's journey has been slow but steady, and a lot more ground needs to be covered. This includes enlisting more qualified vendors, increasing awareness among consumers, setting measurable, time-bound targets and guiding prosumers (those who produce and consume) who face challenges after installing rooftop solar (RTS) systems.

"Both the central government and state governments have jurisdiction over electricity. Initially, there were bottlenecks in synchronising details of electricity department with the PM Surya Ghar portal, which were ironed out," says L.R. Venkatesh, secretary, Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association (TNSEDA).

In the first year, many new consumers complained of delayed payment and long processing time which has drastically reduced in the last one year. Short supply of domestic panels also derailed the installation process.

Currently, a total of 1,376 registered vendors are enlisted on the PM Surya Ghar portal.

"From less than 200 vendors, we now have more than 1,000," says Venkatesh, who is managing director Vesat Renewables.

The implementing agencies have started to take vendors to task. "Very



Participants at a solar rooftop installation competition.

The top five districts

- Coimbatore: 8,107
- Chennai: 6,550
- Chengalpattu: 4,441
- Salem: 3,067
- Erode: 2,985

* This data pertains to number of installations until December 2025

often we see inspections happening randomly, which is good to establish quality in the system. Vendors are being asked to follow all procedures or they can be blacklisted. We are conducting training programmes for listed vendors so that they can upskill themselves with the latest in the renewable energy sector," says Venkatesh.

Implementing agencies

Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited along with Rural Electrification Corporation has been working with vendors to iron out wrinkles in the system.

A senior official says two initiatives that has taken solar rooftop to this stage is the monthly meetings they host among vendors to clarify nagging doubts. The Corporation has also set aside targets, district-wise, with the section officer being held responsible for ensuring a minimum stipulated number of installations for the area. Based on the criterion of meeting targets (which vary from district to district), Chengalpattu was declared as the top-performing district.

The Ministry of New and Renewable

What they say

'We have asked vendors in Chennai to focus on gated communities'

A lot more needs to be done to increase awareness among consumers. In Chennai, there are many apartment complexes and gated communities, so we have asked our members to focus on resident welfare associations as some are of the impression that the PM Surya Ghar scheme is not applicable to them. Power consumption in the common areas at gated communities is huge and by installing solar photovoltaic systems in the common areas, the benefit is extended to every resident. The space is uniformly distributed among residents and there will be reduction in the maintenance bill.

L. R. Venkatesh, secretary, Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association

Energy aims to install 30GW of rooftop solar capacity by 2027 and a lot more needs to be done.

A report brought out by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) in April 2025 on 'How are Indian States Enabling Rooftop Solar Adoption?' suggests setting clear, time-bound targets to establish the state's vision for rooftop solar, mandate solarisation of government buildings, standardise the installation process, create the right economic incentives for consumers, and create a rooftop solar data registry.

'Solar panels at electronic stores!'

Last year, Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group (CAG) conducted at least 50 meetings, both for gated communities and other stakeholder. This year, we are working towards covering more ground. For example, we want to bring banks, TNGECL, solar developers and RWAs on one platform that will promote adoption of rooftop solar systems. We are also working on skilling and upskilling programmes in solar energy adoption for those in the allied skill pool such as electricians and architects, and also exploring how rooftop solar panels can find space on the shelves of electronic stores by working with electrical and electronics retailers.

K. Vishnu Mohan Rao, Programme Lead, CAG

'Create awareness about maintenance of panels'

As a prosumer for more than two years now, one lesson learnt is not to ignore the need to maintain solar panels. The quality and quantity of energy produced can decrease significantly if not maintained. I had not discussed maintenance with my vendor when I invested in a solar rooftop system and neither was I aware that AMC contract is available. The vendor too did not guide me. Now, twice a year I reach out to other technicians/service providers to get this work.

Logendrakumar M.K., president, Chettinad Enclave Village Owners Association, Pallikaranai

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A medley of events at inter-collegiate fest



Actor and filmmaker R. Parthiban with other guests

The entrepreneurial skills of students were also showcased

Students from more than 70 colleges took part in Sardar 2026, the inter-collegiate cultural festival of A M Jain College, Meenambakkam. The two-day saw competitions in dance, music, and fine arts.

Actor Sampath Ram, S. Pushparaj, Inspector of Police and Vijay Jain, a member of the management committee, were among those who took part in the inaugural function.

An electrifying live concert by popular playback singers Sam

Vishal and Malavika Sundar was the highlight, said a release.

Actor and filmmaker R. Parthiban was honoured for his contribution to Indian cinema and creative arts.

The college also hosted the 'AMJACIAN' bazaar, featuring over 100 stalls, transforming the campus into a lively marketplace.

The bazaar provided students and young entrepreneurs with a solid platform to showcase innovative products, creative ideas, and business ventures.

Actress Malavika Manoj and T T F Vasan, a YouTuber, also attended the festival, the release added.

A fund raiser for those with special needs



Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School in Kelambakkam recently organised a student-led walkathon, which was conceptualised and led by students of grade VIII.

Held at the Health City campus, surrounded by lush greenery, the walkathon offered parti-

cipants an opportunity to support a cause while promoting health and well-being, said a release. The students raised funds for Sri Arunodayam Charitable Trust, an organisation that empowers individuals with special needs. The funds raised will contribute to the trust's ongoing

work in providing essential care, resources, and opportunities for those they serve, added the release. The initiative is part of the service learning project of the students, where they demonstrated leadership, empathy, and a strong sense of purpose, the release added.

35 special schools take part in Freedom Carnival



Ooruni Foundation organised its annual event, Freedom Carnival 2026, recently at Vels University, Pallavaram. According to a press release, the event was a platform to empower children with special needs by giving them a safe and inclusive environment

where they can explore their abilities and express themselves freely.

This year, around 1,000 children from 35 schools, took part. Parents and special educators accompanied them.

Various games were conduct-

ed. The other activities included: drawing and painting and dance. Food counters were set up.

Also, there were sessions for parents handled by Dr. K.K. Dhavendran, Principal and Head of Unit for Cerebral Palsy at NIPMED; Akila Palani, Director of Bright The Learning Center & Early Intervention Services India, and Annapoorna Raj, Founder, Inspire Lives Trust.

These sessions provided insights on rights and policies for persons with disabilities, enhancing communication, and integrated education with vocational development. Ooruni Foundation is a registered non-profit organisation committed to sustainable community development, adds the release.

Automation expo from March 12

IED Communications Limited will conduct a three-day 'Automation Expo South 2026' from March 12 at Chennai Trade Centre. The expo would have two zones: the robotics zone, where over 15 companies will be showcasing the latest in industrial robots, collaborative robots, and next-gen intelligent automation.

The second zone is sustainability and

specialised tech, automation in water and waste water management will be shown, said a release. A core mission of the expo is to bridge the gap between education and industry. The 'Back to Basics 2.0' workshop will provide essential, hands-on technical training for future engineers, the release added. For details, visit south.automationindiaexpo.com

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